The last few years have also encouraged us all to become more digitalized. We, in India, have a record that is generating widespread respect for good reasons. The scale of our digital delivery, whether it is in food, finance, health, pension or social benefits, is very much the talk of the world. Here, too, the visible efficiency of that transformation has been accompanied by corresponding risks of data privacy and data security. Where our data resides and who harvests it matter increasingly. The political sociology of such residency or processing is no longer irrelevant.

As a result, trust and transparency have become important guiding factors in digital decision-making. This is even more relevant as we enter a world increasingly driven by artificial intelligence (AI). The potential of critical and emerging technologies (CET) also poses its own set of issues. Whether it is for climate change or strategic concerns, countries have shifted towards greener and cleaner sources of energy and mobility. The resources, technologies and production associated with them have their own concentrations and consequential vulnerabilities. As a result, nations have made CET a priority for both their national capabilities as well as their collaborative endeavours.

Beyond the intricacies of supply chains and the vulnerabilities of data harvesting, there are larger changes underway in international affairs. These emanate from the weaponization of a broad range of services and activities that were regarded till now as essentially benign. In recent times, we saw how trade, connectivity, debt, resources and even tourism became points of political pressure. The Ukraine conflict has dramatically widened the scope and intensity of such leveraging. The scale of financial measures, technology controls, service restrictions and seizure of assets has been truly breathtaking.

At the same time, it is also an undeniable fact that global rules, regimes and practices have been gamed for national advantage for decades. In that scenario, the world of comparative advantage had no chance against ‘unrestricted economics’. The complacency of the previous era has ended decisively, and each line of questioning now is producing deeply uncomfortable realizations. Sharpening great power competition is inevitably enhancing stress factors across multiple domains. And they will not cease simply because vested interests and political correctness wish to cover them up. The challenge for many nations, including India, is whether they can be converted into opportunities.